

RAJWANT RAWAT

Q. Large stretches of the national highways also saw landslides....

A. The four-lane highways do not make any difference. The challenge lies in cutting the hills. It should have tunnels instead. The Kalka to Shimla railway tracks were laid in 1905 and it had 103 tunnels. Tunnels do not alter the character of the hills. If you cut hills to widen the roads, the soil strata needs 4-6 years to settle into the new shape. The contractors from outside do not care for the nuances of the hills. The NHAI (National Highways Authority of India) has built large tracts of highways in the state, only some portions faced issues. Landslides have happened earlier too—it is normal in the hills—but this time, the number of incidents was a thousand times more.

Q. The TV channels had shown dramatic visuals of buildings collapsing in Shimla and Kullu, but how bad is the situation in the remote parts of the state?

A. The damage is huge. In several stretches, the hills have collapsed, impacting several habitats. I went to Sarkaghat, Mandi, Solan, Hamirpur, Kangra... there are scattered areas there where the whole hill has collapsed. This is not a product of urbanisation, this is due to climate change. The intensity of the rains was so high that the water seeped through the mountains. Hills with standing trees have shifted position. It is high time we did detailed studies on the collapse of the mountains and the impact of climate change. These recent events have come as an eye-opener for us. The experts must study why the hills have come down by 50 feet in many spots.

Q. Shimla was designed for 50,000 people but now houses a population 5-6 times the size. Do you think new cities are needed?

A. We are thinking on those lines. We are trying to identify the state departments which can be shifted out. In the past 75 years, Himachal has not created any new city. Hill states should have small cities, even though 90 per cent of our population lives in villages. We are planning a new city near Shimla, Jatia Devi, and have already started feasibility studies there. A few offices will be shifted there along with residential complexes.

Q. There are also issues related to waste disposal....

A. It's true that encroachment has happened in certain areas along the rivers and nullahs. The dumped waste had choked some of them, obstructing the flow of water. Waste disposal is a complex issue. Himachal Pradesh has 68 per cent forest cover and constitutes the lungs of north India. We don't get any compensation for this. Waste disposal requires clearances under the laws governing forest conservation and forest regulations. Since they are difficult to procure, many dump the waste in the nullah and rivers. In the Larji project (on the Beas river), we are now facing damages worth about Rs 1,000 crore because of the NHAI. They constructed a flyover there, and dumped the concrete waste in the Beas. It changed the course of the river and diverted the water to the Larji project. I have conveyed to the Union environment minister my misgivings and asked the ministry to allow us to denotify some areas to dump the waste so as to prevent such incidents in the future.

> **“HILL STATES SHOULD HAVE SMALL CITIES. HIMACHAL HAS NOT CREATED A NEW ONE IN THE PAST 75 YEARS. WE ARE PLANNING ONE NEAR SHIMLA”**

Q. How has the Centre responded to the crisis in the state?

A. I have met Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah, surface transport minister Nitin Gadkari and many others and asked for the floods to be declared a national calamity. We also need financial support to rebuild the state. Till now, they have all extended full support. The state has seen huge revenue losses in the past two months because of this calamity. GST collections are down, so is our VAT on liquor and petroleum products (because of low tourist footfalls). If there are no rains, by mid-September, we will clear all the roads. Our financial situation was never that great, and the floods have only made it worse.

Q. Will this delay the implementation of your poll promises such as bringing back the old pension scheme (OPS) and allowances for all women?

A. We are trying to save money by changing certain policies and plugging corruption and we are determined to rebuild the state in the next four years. We have implemented OPS, and this is not a freebie but protection for our citizens. We will give pension to the women as well. It is our right to claim money from the Centre. They collect taxes from us. They don't compensate us for the forest cover, our raw material (water) that is used to generate electricity. We have asked the private players in hydel projects for a cess on the electricity charges.

Q. What are the big-ticket measures you want to take to revive the state's economy?

A. We have to revive tourism in the state. Kangra could become a tourism capital as an international airport is coming up there. Himachal has the potential to become the greenest state of the country, but for that electric vehicles have to be pushed aggressively, as also greener energies like solar and hydel. We have set the target for the greenest state. We are also augmenting the medical education facilities, and setting up Rajeev Gandhi day boarding schools.